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STORIES

THE SINNER STANDARD

Jannik Sinner overcame an inspired Alexander Zverev to **retain** his Wimbledon crown, once again raising his level when it mattered most to claim a fifth Grand Slam title.

Paul Fein

Before Alexander Zverev captured his first Grand Slam title at Roland Garros, Rafael Nadal advised him to be braver. Now, Zverev had to summon the same winning formula against Jannik Sinner, a much tougher foe than Flavio Cobolli, in the Wimbledon final.

Zverev had talked the talk. When World No. 1 Sinner belted a forehand passing-shot winner and a 134-mph ace for a 7-6 lead and set point in the opening-set tie-break, Sascha had to walk the walk. The 6'6" German responded with ferocity — a 134-mph ace, a cross-court backhand winner, and a 100 mph inside-out forehand winner — to seize the set, 7-6(7).

Zverev's forehand, previously a passive weak link that stalled his otherwise powerful game, had morphed into an explosive weapon. "His forehand is averaging 10 mph faster than Sinner's," said *ESPN* analyst Andy Roddick. "This is bananas!"

Another startling statistic: Zverev, who used to retreat far behind the baseline, hit 31 per cent of his groundstrokes inside the baseline

compared to 29 per cent for the hyper-aggressive Sinner during the tournament.

Although Sinner had won their last nine matches, they had never played on grass before. The rainless fortnight made the courts bone dry. "The court conditions help Zverev," said *ESPN* analyst Patrick McEnroe before the final. "It's almost like playing on hard courts. Zverev has to serve huge on both serves. I really think this match will be a lot closer than people think."

IBM Watson gave Sinner, a four-time Major winner and the defending champion, a 62 per cent chance of victory, with 1-5 odds for bettors. Those odds became a little more even after Zverev's impressive opening set.

But could the 29-year-old Zverev maintain his high level to pull off an upset? Not if history was any guide. No man had ever won back-to-back Grand Slam titles after winning his first. Also, was it plausible that Sinner, who racked up a 30-match winning streak early this season, would lose the final and thus not hold any Major titles, his last Slam trophy having come here a year ago?